

THE GREAT WAR

THE CONFLICT THAT CHANGED THE NATURE OF WAR FOREVER

World War I (Aug 1914–Nov 1918) was also known as the Great War. Although it was a global conflict, the focus was Europe, where the Central Powers—Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Turkey—fought an alliance led by France, Britain, and Russia. The US entered the war on the Anglo-French side in 1917.

From the outset, the decisive arena of conflict was Germany's Western Front. The Germans invaded neutral Belgium and Luxembourg, overcoming Belgian resistance at Liege and Antwerp. French and British forces were driven into retreat southward after clashes at Mons and Charleroi. At the Marne, however, French commander General Joseph Joffre rallied his forces for a counter-offensive and the Germans were pushed back.

After a desperate struggle at Ypres in the fall of 1914, the rival armies dug into trenches that stretched from the North Sea to Switzerland. Massive resources were committed to offensives—

by the Germans at Verdun and by the Western Allies at the Somme—without breaking the stalemate. Up to 1918, only a voluntary withdrawal by the Germans to the fortified Hindenburg Line significantly changed the position of the armies.

From March 1918 a series of large-scale German offensives broke through Allied defenses and advanced the front line toward Paris. But, aided by the arrival of US troops, the Allies halted the Germans at the Marne. A successful British offensive at Amiens in August initiated the "Hundred Days," a series of advances that pushed the fighting back close to the German border.

BRITAIN

London

English Channel

The Western Front
Millions of troops were compressed into a restricted area of northeastern France and western Belgium. It was here that most of the largest and bloodiest battles of the war were fought.

KEY

- Front line 1914–1916
- Hindenburg Line
- Front line Mar 1918
- Furthest extent of German advance 1918
- Armistice Nov 1918
- Major battle

A WAR ON ALL FRONTS

On the Eastern Front, Germany and Austria-Hungary faced the forces of the Russian Empire. From the battle of Tannenberg in August 1914, the German Army established an ascendancy over the Russians, but the Austro-Hungarians enjoyed no such superiority, suffering defeat in the Russian Brusilov offensive in 1916. Revolution in Russia in 1917 led to the country's exit from the war, and a humiliating peace treaty with Germany signed at Brest-Litovsk in March 1918.

The entry of the Turkish Ottoman Empire into the war as an ally of Germany in the fall of 1914 spread the conflict to the Middle East. An Anglo-French bid to attack the Turkish capital, Constantinople, failed dismally at Gallipoli.

Bulgaria also joined the Central Powers, helping to crush Serbia in 1915 and Romania the following year. Allied troops based at Salonica in northern Greece from 1915 remained largely passive until the final months of the war, when their advance northward in September 1918 helped deliver a decisive blow to the collapsing Central Powers.



THE EASTERN FRONT

Fought mostly in East Prussia, Poland, and Galicia, the war between Russia and the Central Powers brought Russia to political and military collapse. Peace terms enabled Germany to occupy Russian territory.

KEY

- Front line 1914–15 (limit of Russian advance)
- Limit of Austro-German advance 1915–16
- Brusilov offensive 1916
- Armistice line Dec 1917
- German penetration into Russia by 1918
- Major battle



THE BALKANS Serbia resisted attacks by Austria-Hungary, but was overrun once Germany and Bulgaria joined in. The Allies landed troops at Salonica and Gallipoli, and many retreating Serbs joined the Allies at Salonica.

KEY

- Salonican front Sep 1918
- Austrian, German, and Bulgarian advance 1915
- Retreating Serbs 1915
- Allied offensive Sep 1918
- Romanian offensive Aug–Sep 1916